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Marriage

Definition, Functions and Forms...

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Definition of Marriage

- Westermarck
  - Marriage is a ritually recognized union b/w a man and a woman, so that the spouses live together and that the couple have recognized mutual sexual rights
- Murdock
  - Marriage is a universal institution that involves residential cohabitation, economic cooperation and result in the formation of nuclear families

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Definition of Marriage

- Seligman
  - Marriage is a union b/w a man and a woman such that the children born to the woman are recognized as legitimate offspring of both the parents
- William Stephen
  - Marriage is a socially legitimate sexual union, began with public pronouncement, undertaken with a idea of permanence, assumed with more or less explicit marriage contract which spells out reciprocal economic obligations b/w the spouses and b/w the spouses and their future children

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Why the difficulty?

- Three functions
  - Sexual Rights
  - Economic Responsibilities
  - Rights over Children
- **Not derived from relationships resulting from marriage**

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Characteristics

1. Charter
2. Mate Choice
3. Financial Transaction - Bride Price, Dowry, Gift Exchanges
4. Ceremonials
5. Residence
6. Authority
7. Stability

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Functions of Marriage

1. Biological Function
2. Economic Function
3. Social Function
4. Educational Function

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Rules of Marriage

Proscriptive	**Prescriptive**	**Preferential**
"Should Not"	"Should"	"Can"
Incest Taboo	Exogamy Endogamy	Cousin Marriages Levirate Sororate Hypergamy

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Proscriptive Rules

1. Inbreeding Avoidance - David Aberle
2. Familiarity Breeds Avoidance - Westermarck
3. Preventing Disruption of Family - Malinowski / Freud
4. Forming Wider Alliances - Claude Levi Strauss

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Prescriptive Rules

Exogamy

1. Extension of familial incest taboo
2. Paleolithic Hunter gatherers – maintaining survival of the groups- Tylor
3. Desire to have a variety in life – Herbert Risley
4. Scarcity – infanticide – Audrey Richards

Endogamy

1. Preventing intermixture of blood

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Preferential Rules

- Cousin Marriages
  - Parallel Cousin Marriages
  - Cross Cousin Marriages
    - Matrilateral Cross Cousin Marriages
    - Patrilateral Cross Cousin Marriages
- Levirate
- Sororate
- Hypergamy - Anuloma

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Number of Mates

- Monogamy
- Polygamy
  - Polyandry
  - Polygyny
- Group Marriages

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Monogamy

1. Economic considerations
2. Population factors
3. Preferential and prescribed marriage rules

Serial Monogamy

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Polygamy

- Polygyny
- Polyandry
  - General Polyandry
  - Adelphic or Fraternal Polyandry

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Why Polyandry?

1. Lesser number of women
2. Poverty – scarcity – many men support one woman and her children
3. High bride price
4. To strengthen extended families

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Why Polygyny?

1. Associated with slavery – Rajahs
2. Long Periods of Enforced celibacy – pregnant / breast feeding
3. Earlier aging of women
4. Variety
5. More children
6. Social Prestige
7. Economic necessity – women are more reliable laborers as wives

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Ways of Acquiring Mates

1. Probation - Kuki
2. Capture - Nagas/Gonds
3. Elopement
4. Trial - Bhills
5. Service - Birhor/Gonds/Baiga
6. Purchase
7. Inheritance of widows - Sema Nagas
8. Intrusion - Birhor/Ho

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Divorce

- Generally the outcome of long process of mutual alienation b/w couple
- We cannot precisely say what causes “high” divorce rates
- Some aspects of social and cultural structure are responsible for it

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Divorce

- **When are the Divorce Rates High?**

1. When conditions make incompatibility b/w husband and wife more likely
2. Barriers to divorce are lowered
3. Satisfactory alternatives are available to the unhappy marriage

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Factors

- The factors producing divorce rates – impinge unequally upon different groups in a population
- Consequently, the divorce rates vary a/c to religion, social class, occupations etc.

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Factors

1. Religious Tolerance of Divorce
2. Legal Tolerance of Divorce
3. Increased Industrialization – Economic independence / commercialization of services
4. Urbanization – Reduction of social control

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Factors Contd...

5. Birth Control – Relation b/w deliberate birth control and divorce rates
6. Higher Vertical Social Mobility – unequal adaptation to new conditions
7. Heterogeneity of Population – Greater chances of marriage b/w social and culturally incompatible persons
8. High demands on intimate and affectionate

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